

Afro-Virginian Foodways

Before continuing with this section, make sure you have read the article by Franklin assigned for this module.

The identity of the Afro-Virginians whom Franklin describes in this reading is complex. She notes that in the 18th century, this community was dynamic, evolving, and multi-layered; some of its members were enslaved individuals from Africa, while others were born enslaved in America, and others traced multiple lineages of free and enslaved ancestors, only some of whom may have identified as Black. Franklin also notes the importance of understanding the difference between racial categories imposed by white slaveowners—"Anglo-Virginians," as they are termed here—and the ways in which enslaved individuals viewed their own identities. One aim of the author is to understand how Afro-Virginians enslaved at the Rich Neck Plantation viewed their own identity and constructed it through foodways that, in turn, reinforced both their identity and the identity of Anglo-Virginians as "not black." As Franklin states, "I then argue that eighteenth-century enslaved Virginians responded to the conditions and constrictions of their enslavement (including poverty, plantation food rationing, and surveillance of their activities) through active collaboration in forging a system of foodways that demonstrated self-sufficiency, creativity, and careful strategizing in creating this cultural institution" (p. 89).

The site investigated here, Rich Neck Plantation, was a tobacco plantation owned by one of Virginia's wealthiest men, Phillip Ludwell III, who lived at another of his plantations several miles away. In 1767, the enslaved community at Rich Neck included 21 people: 15 adults, some of whom were elderly and had almost certainly been enslaved in Africa, and 6 children. Franklin suggests that two enslaved families inhabited the building excavated.

Franklin notes the challenges faced by the enslaved community in preparing food that they found meaningful and fulfilling. There were few African domesticated plants available in Virginia, so a new cuisine needed to be created that made use of local Native American domesticates, European domesticates grown locally, and wild plant and animal resources. A second challenge was finding time to grow food for themselves to supplement the rations provided them by the plantation, which were often insufficient for proper nutrition. Even food preparation would have been challenging, given the long and exhausting field work demanded in the tobacco fields.

What did these enslaved individuals eat? A great variety of wild animals—from rabbits and deer to squirrels, turtles, pigeons, and many types of fish and shellfish—in addition to domesticated animals: cattle, pigs, sheep and goats, and chickens. Of these, cattle and pigs provided the large majority of the meat supply. Plant foods included a variety of wild foods, as well—especially fruits and nuts available locally—as well as a variety of American domesticates grown by indigenous people in the area (beans, corn, squash, peanuts) and European-introduced crops (wheat, barley, rye, and watermelon).

How were these foods cooked? As we saw with Popper's research into Market Street Chinatown earlier, Franklin used historical evidence to understand the cultural context of cooking and cuisine made from the ingredients identified archaeologically. Franklin notes that women were likely the cooks and used cooking techniques common in West Africa, such as stewing and baking. The importance of one-pot stewing is confirmed by the fragmentation of animal bones from the site, with cut marks that indicate that large pieces of meat were cut into smaller pieces for cooking—likely in stews, which would have also extracted nutrients (fat and protein) from the bones themselves. Franklin notes the advantages of stewing: It requires little supervision, can take place throughout an otherwise busy day, and tenderizes tough meat. Ash-baked corn cakes were likely another staple food.